

Communication & Language

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NOUNS

accent

the distinctive way a person pronounces words, typical of their region, country, or social background

She still has a slight French accent, even after twenty years in London.

interpreter

a person who translates speech aloud so that people who don't share a language can communicate

The hospital arranged an interpreter for her appointment.

jargon

specialised vocabulary used within a particular profession or group, often unclear to outsiders

The report was so full of technical jargon that nobody outside the IT department understood it.

intonation

the rise and fall of the pitch of the voice while speaking

Her rising intonation at the end of the sentence made it sound like a question.

loanword

a term taken from another language and used with little or no change

'Déjà vu' is a loanword the English language borrowed straight from French.

expletive

a swear word, especially one used to express anger, pain, or surprise

He let out a stream of expletives when he stubbed his toe on the doorframe.

ADJECTIVES

fluent

able to speak or write a language easily, accurately, and without hesitation

After a year working in Tokyo, he became fluent in Japanese.

emoji

a small digital image or icon used to express an idea, object, or feeling in a message

She replied to his apology with nothing but a shrugging emoji.

slang

very informal words and expressions, typically used in speech among particular groups

Half the slang my students use, I have to look up myself.

dialect

a regional or social variety of a language with its own vocabulary, grammar, and pronunciation

Geordie is a dialect from the north-east of England that some outsiders find hard to follow.

neologism

a word or expression newly coined and not yet in general use

'Photobomb' was a neologism a decade ago; now it's a household word.

vernacular

the everyday language spoken by ordinary people in a particular place, as opposed to formal or literary language

The play is written entirely in the local vernacular, which makes it tricky for non-natives to follow.

diplomatic

skilled at dealing with people or difficult situations without causing offence

Try to be diplomatic when you explain why the project is running late.

blunt

very direct in speech, without trying to soften the message

He's painfully blunt sometimes, but at least you always know where you stand.

moribund

in terminal decline and likely to disappear completely, especially of a language, custom, or institution

The dialect is now moribund, spoken fluently by only a handful of elderly residents.

tactful

careful not to say or do anything that might embarrass or upset someone

She was tactful enough not to mention his mistake in front of the whole team.

straight-talking

honest and direct in speech, without avoiding difficult or awkward truths

She's known as a straight-talking manager who always tells you exactly where you stand.

VERBS

pronounce

to say a word or sound in a particular way

It took me weeks to learn how to pronounce his name correctly.

translate

to express the meaning of words or text in a different language

Could you translate this sign for me? I can't read a word of it.

enunciate

to pronounce words clearly and distinctly

The radio presenter was trained to enunciate every syllable clearly.

mispronounce

to pronounce a word incorrectly

Tourists often mispronounce the name of the town.

rephrase

to say or write something again using different words

Could you rephrase the question? I'm not sure what you're asking.

sugarcoat

to make something unpleasant or difficult sound more acceptable than it really is

Don't sugarcoat it, just tell me if the presentation was bad.

PHRASAL VERBS

look up

to search for a piece of information, for example in a dictionary or online

I looked the word up on my phone the moment he said it.

die out

to gradually disappear or stop existing

Without younger speakers, the language will die out within a generation.

tone down

to make something less extreme, forceful, or offensive

The editor asked her to tone down some of the language in the article.

catch on

to become popular or widely used

The abbreviation caught on so quickly that most people forgot where it came from.

COLLOCATIONS

mother tongue

the first language a person learns as a child

Dutch is her mother tongue, though she now speaks English at work every day.

body language

communication through gestures, posture, and facial expression rather than words

His body language gave him away: arms crossed, eyes down, clearly uncomfortable.

small talk

polite, light conversation about unimportant things, especially with people you don't know well
I'm useless at small talk. I never know what to say at networking events.

text speak

the abbreviated, informal style of writing typical of messaging and online chat
His replies are pure text speak ('u', 'gr8', 'idk') and I can barely read them.

IDIOMS

on the tip of my tongue

describes a word or name you almost remember but can't quite recall
Her name's on the tip of my tongue. Give me a second, it'll come to me.

beat around the bush

avoid saying what you really mean by talking about other things first
Just tell me what happened, don't beat around the bush.

lose the thread

to stop being able to follow what someone is saying
He went off on so many tangents that I completely lost the thread.

SET PHRASES

get your point across

to succeed in making people understand what you mean
He barely speaks any Italian, but somehow he always gets his point across.

MODERN SLANG

waffle

to talk or write a lot without giving any useful information
He waffled for ten minutes without actually answering my question.

false friend

a word in a foreign language that looks similar to one in your own but has a different meaning
'Embarrassed' and 'embarazada' are false friends between English and Spanish: one means embarrassed, the other means pregnant.

lost in translation

describes meaning, humour, or nuance that disappears when something moves from one language to another
A lot of the joke's charm gets lost in translation.

get to the point

to start talking about the main thing you want to say, instead of talking around it
Could you get to the point? We're running out of time.

coin a phrase

to invent a new word or expression
Nobody knows for certain who first coined the phrase 'couch potato'.

watch your language

used to tell someone to stop swearing or speaking rudely
Watch your language, please; there are children in the room.

lingo

language, especially the specialised or unfamiliar vocabulary used by a particular group
I couldn't follow a word of the lawyers' lingo.